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**r/GooglePixel** • 3mo ago

rainbowsunrain

...

Is Google up to the mark in computational photography these days?

The iPhone 17 Pro camera is making heads turn with their new photo processing pipeline. While they have always had a lead in the video department, I've mostly preferred Pixel for their still photos and portraits. Of late though, I'm not so sure if iPhone Pro models fall behind so much and seem to be closing the gap (if not straight up better in some cases).

I've been watching many comparisons between Pixel, Galaxy and iPhone higher-end models. Of those, this one shook me: https://youtu.be/WeEjZCZgwwQ?si=kikV_y71zXdgpN-r. Sure, the landscape is pretty good and natural light is gorgeous, but to be confused with photos from \$10k professional camera is astonishingly good.

This is not a post about Pixels directly; instead, how do Pixels fare compared to other flagships. Do we still value Pixel photography just as much, or is that moat mostly gone? Especially since we are paying just as much an iPhone.

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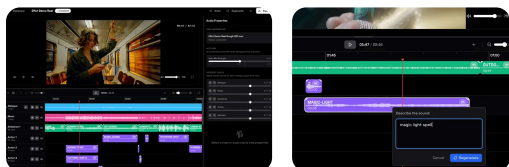
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**bozhodimitrov** • 3mo ago

Pixel 10 Pro

I did a comparison myself, because I don't trust most reviewers. They just want to pump content and never show exactly how they took the images, the methodology and the settings.

Pixel is still very good at taking snaps and excels in certain conditions. I noticed that the iPhone has better software support in apps, this might be because of the iOS specifics. But over all I still prefer the Pixel look, especially with the RAW images, where you can unlock most of the sensors potential.

One thing is for sure, iPhones are closing the gap very fast. I think that the only reason their camera system is still not on top for photos is because they really prioritize video performance over images. Their

[Skip to main content](#)

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**rainbowsunrain** OP • 3mo ago

Yup, they are closing the gap faster. That's concerning as a Pixel fan. Also, I don't see the value proposition going further.

**bozhodimitrov** • 3mo ago

Pixel 10 Pro

Why concerning? I think that competition will be better for us consumers. Look what is going on with the Chinese phones, they have ridiculous amounts of phones and every brand has multiple models competing between each other on every segment of the market.

We should be happy that iPhones are trying to improve and Google should do the same like the early years with OG Pixels. Something more - nowadays the western brands should try to become as good as the Chinese competitive hardware market, because most of the hardware innovations happen in Asia now. Not like the past when the headquarters of western companies like Apple, Nokia, Intel, IBM were the main drivers and the only major asian player was Japan.

**rainbowsunrain** OP • 3mo ago

Sure, I get that. Concerning because I don't see Pixels getting any cheaper, and don't see them catching up to competition in hardware. New TSMC chip was just as lame as before. Overall, I agree competition is good, but Google is company that throws towel at its projects randomly. Especially if they lose more market share going forward.

**[deleted]** • 3mo ago**ralcantara79** • 3mo ago

Pixel 6 Pro

I absolutely loved the results of my Pixel 2XL. When I upgraded to the 6 Pro it was obvious the processing was going in a new direction. Shadows were being lifted to an unnatural degree. But most of all the blues were being over saturated, especially in landscape photos. It was like they wanted the sky to look deep blue like when you wear polarized glasses. The problem was that one, this was not what I was seeing with my eyes and two, it also affected blue objects making them unnaturally more blue. This was more apparent when I would pick up my 2 XL and take side by side photos. The older phone just looked more natural and close to what I was really seeing. Now I've switched to the iPhone 17 Pro and right away I could tell that the photos were much closer to the 2 XL as far as post processing of color, highlights, and shadows. No more deeper blues on everything or unnaturally bright shadows. Those things are left for me to decide how to edit and not immediately applied.

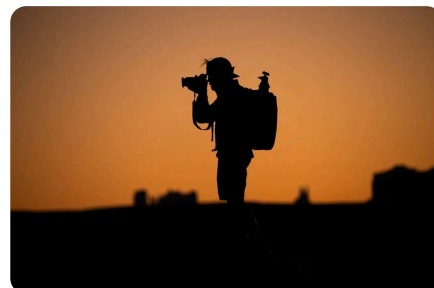
**JadeDream1** • 3mo ago

As a black person, pixel skin tones >> iphone



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[Shop Now](#)guragear.com**Alarmed_Atmosphere** • 3mo ago

One thing which no one is talking about is the camera app situation. iPhone users are getting beautifully crafted creative apps like Halide, Kino, Nofusion, Project Indigo etc for bypassing the smartphone sharpening and getting beautiful no-edit required photos directly. Pixel and Android phones in general are getting left behind. See the recently uploaded video by photographer Alex Armitage where he shows how good these apps are with clever software tricks. David Imel showed it in the waveform podcast too where the panel was shocked by the iPhone camera when paired with these apps. The following may sting but my opinions have shifted in recent months. I feel with Google all in on AI, I think if you are interested in smartphone photography and videography, it's high time to go the iPhone way.

**XandarYT** • 3mo ago

Pixel 8 Pro

iPhones could do anything at all but until they allow third party apps it's a hard nope for me

**[deleted]** • 3mo ago**chic_luke** • 3mo ago

Pixel 2 XL

Agree completely.

I decided to switch things up and try a Samsung flagship this time around for the superior hardware, counting on the fact that... you know, I can return it if I don't like it. So far, I am still hesitant on keeping it and erring towards returning it.

And let's say, one of the major reasons why I am undecided would be a non-issue if Android, like iOS, had the same park of alternative camera apps and ways to skip the on-device post processing. The camera hardware on the Galaxy is getting a bit dated, but *it's not bad*, and it's not what causes the problem - Samsung's heavy post processing is. And, after following tons of guides and advice, there is really no acceptable way around it. Even with RAW photos, you still cannot escape the post processing.

I think this is a *pity*. Basically, it tightly couples the default post processing algorithm a phone uses with the phone itself, and it cannot easily be swapped out. Which is surprising for Android: isn't it

[Skip to main content](#)

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a lot of us still opt to put up with the issues with recent pixels (QA, efficiency and the full list you know and hate), not exclusively but majorly because the camera's post processing is not invasive like the one you find on Samsung, Oppo, Realme, now OnePlus, and so on, and so forth...

**XandarYT** • 3mo ago

Pixel 8 Pro

Pixels actually have camera extension APIs which allow third party apps to use ultrawide/telephoto cameras, macro mode, night sight, HDR+, portrait mode, custom focus... On them the camera works in third party apps basically the same as in the official app (minus some additional software features of the Pixel Camera app). Though most other Android devices do not have this as the manufacturers don't bother to include it. However for Pixels it is very good indeed.

**n3cr0ph4g1st** • 3mo ago

Examples?

Does [proCCD](#) take advantage for example?**XandarYT** • 3mo ago

Pixel 8 Pro

I have no idea what that app is, I'm telling you the API is there and a lot of apps like social media utilize it. One good example of a third party camera app that utilizes it is the GrapheneOS Camera (which can also be installed on other systems).

**Vaxion** • 3mo ago

Project Indigo is amazing and my default camera app right now. Shocking that Adobe is offering it for free. Won't be surprised if they put it behind a subscription in the future when it's stable enough.

**No-Instance8041** • 3mo ago**jmreagle** • 3mo ago<https://youtu.be/wHSqy34rjGk?si=NFqRtUpqg8rmtHvG>**rainbowsunrain** **OP** • 3mo ago

Absolutely true! Not only the third party apps, but also external lens mounts and such from Moment are now only supported for iPhones. I was looking around to enhance my phone photography and found that pretty much editing is all what one relies on in Pixels since most third party solutions are getting exclusive to Apple's dominance.

No-Instance8041 • 3mo ago

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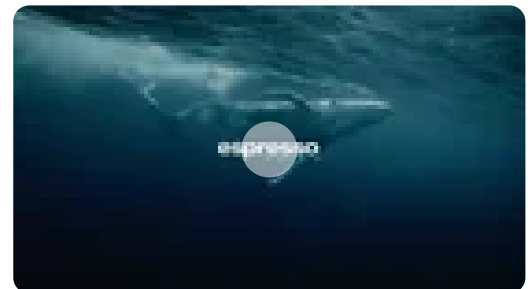
offered. Hipstamatic or I don't remember the name and many others like the one where you could paint on it with markers or brushes and spray paints and different effects. It was only the iPhone 4s that I found great when shooting without effects. I finally switched to Huawei because Leica and I stayed until the p30 pro which was really top photo level everyone told me. Then I let myself be tempted by the Google Pixel 9 Pro and I had difficulty with the photo, especially in low light. So aside from security and gemini I think the iPhone is better for that reason.

**whispy_snippet** • 3mo ago

The Pixel 10 line has a brand new custom ISP and I feel it really shows. It seems like Google has dialed back the heavy handed processing and their images look a lot more flattering than in recent generations. It's still got a distinct Pixel look but things feel more restrained. To be honest the 10 series (I have the Pro) has taken the biggest step forward in pure image quality since the Pixel 2. I do wish we had some custom picture profiles to enable different looks straight out of camera, but the images themselves generally look really great for a phone. I still think Google has Apple pretty comfortably covered in most (but not all) aspects of still shooting image quality.

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I don't use iPhones or keep up with much of what changes on them lately.

But I'm confused with the video because they are talking about processed raw photos that they used for the comparison. That removes most of the aspect of computational photography from this post's question. And this isn't the way I use my phone camera. It's literally a point-and-shoot one time camera for me (maybe twice on certain occasions), and that's where I think Pixels shine. I think iPhones do this very well these days. So from a computational photography standpoint I still think Google is at a fine place. While DXO Mark is dubious in some ways, looking at the individual breakdown of still camera categories, and also comparing the actual photo examples, I don't think, aside from iPhone handling portrait photos better, there is a meaningful difference in still photos between the iPhone 17 Pro Max and the 10 Pro XL or 9 Pro XL. *With the exception of zooming beyond 5x in the telephoto camera on the Pixels.* I don't know what happened but Google outputs some pretty poor results from the telephoto when zoomed beyond 5x. It's like there is a sudden drop of detail, things look tessellated, etc. But from the main sensor, it's all pretty good.

[Skip to main content](#)[Create](#)

more than the state of google's computational photography.



Harry93_V • 3mo ago

some users will come for you bro. I've been saying this for a while, Tensor is the single bottleneck right now. iPhone supports live filters and real-time editing in the camera app thanks to its SoC. It's not magic, it has the power to pull it off.

When I mentioned that P10 could not record in 4K HDR 60fps I was told that it wasn't necessary and pro users should get a camera. I guess they'll say you should use Photoshop and get a RTX for proper editing lol



rainbowsunrain OP • 3mo ago

They are coming for me lol. I'm having so many downvotes for engaging in a discussion.



Unspec7 • 3mo ago

Pixel 10 Pro XL

Year after year Tensor falls further behind, and year after year Tensor fanbois find another way to explain it away.



Possible_Law8357 • 3mo ago • Edited 3mo ago

Pixel 10 Pro Pixel watch 4 Pixel Buds Pro

I find pixel over processes and produces washed out colors. Galaxy over saturates. iPhone photos are in between so more balanced than the other two IMO.

If I look at my old pixel 3 photos and compare with latest pixel photos, they look almost the same. They were so much ahead at that time but they slacked and iPhone caught up from behind.



acid-burn2k3 • 3mo ago

Yeah I agree. They denied hardware too much. Their A.I post process was impressive 10 years ago. But it's almost 2026.. and their photography seems more and more ass to me



Possible_Law8357 • 3mo ago

Pixel 10 Pro Pixel watch 4 Pixel Buds Pro

Google needs to get those Sony larger 9xx sensors as main camera.

Instead they are going on a direction with some software gimmicks.



Esguelha • 3mo ago • Edited 3mo ago

[Skip to main content](#)[+ Create](#)**Possible_Law8357** • 3mo ago • Edited 3mo ago

Pixel 10 Pro Pixel watch 4 Pixel Buds Pro

They were good for that time, but time changes and technology advances. If you stick to what's good 10 years ago then it's not going to be good 10 years later. We move forward. Why is this so hard to understand? For example, fhd videos might be good 10 years ago but not now 10y after when there's 4k 60fps HDR commonly available.

**Low_Coconut_7642** • 3mo ago

The final result HAS improved versus older pixels

They have just moved away from the Early Pixel Look with deep contrasty shadows.

**Esguelha** • 3mo ago

But if 75 out of 100 people prefer the old look and can no longer get it, has it really improved? You can certainly apply metrics to pictures, but at the end of the day it's a subjective medium, and the better picture is probably the one that people like the most.

**Any_Manager_106** • 3mo ago

I use the option "use rich colour in photos" in the camera settings. No issue with colours on pixel 9 pro although I do wish sometimes the photo was brighter which it is after 1 click in Google photos to optimise it. It's easier to fix than S24U which over brightened the shadows and iPhone 15 pro max which was too yellow. Apart from the white balance I found saturation to be pretty similar. The S23U series over saturated images but that's not the case now. That said 17 pro max is probably a big step up from the 15

**Esguelha** • 3mo ago

Did you watch the video? They're post-processed RAW pictures and they're specifically saying that they would be much worse if they let the phone do their thing.

**rainbowsunrain** **OP** • 3mo ago

Good point! I watched it; they discussed how they didn't let some of the processing be done by iPhone and used RAW.

But I'm still amazed at how close it was to an expensive professional camera. Capturing the shadows, enabling a wide dynamic range, sharp images that don't lose too much detail upon zooming. I'm sure Pixels RAW photos could be similar too, but that's my point --- the distinct advantage of using Pixel may not be all that distinct anymore.

[Skip to main content](#)

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I have one question for Google pixels. I use both iPhone and android (non-pixel). Both are flagships from their brand. What I find frustrating is that the android camera viewfinder still sucks compared to iPhone. Low res, low frame rate, no live HDR, no live depth effect. On the iPhone what I see on the viewfinder is almost identical to the final output, delivering a wysiwyg experience. I know this was the case many years ago but I still couldn't believe this is still present in 2025. Quite unacceptable.

Do Pixels have the same issue?

**partakinginsillyness** • 3mo ago

I can't speak on the HDR being perfect, but it seems fine to me using google camera on a 9 pro (GrapheneOS if it matters)

**acid-burn2k3** • 3mo ago

Yes they do! It's super annoying.

**dezirdtuzurnaim** • 3mo ago

Pixel 9 Pro XL

I've owned multiple Galaxies and Pixels 2-9 and most of the Nexus devices before that.

I've been a loyal Android user since 2012. I've used but never owned an iPhone. To me the OS was just so bland and boring. I also didn't love the idea of being strapped to a single device OEM.

Over the years, cellphone "photography" has always been a contentious topic. I've personally preferred Samsung's and Google's style compared to Apple's. But, there have times where iPhone did take the better shot. All subjective of course but there have also been countless examples of RAW images being analyzed for "correctiveness" and it's back and forth.

That being said. I recently switched, for reasons, to iPhone 17 Pro from Pixel 9 Pro XL.

Still photos are as good if not better on the iPhone comparatively. The videos however are leagues apart! For both photos and videos, the view finder is far superior and the resulting shots are near enough the same. WYSIWYG. The processing is done in realtime, which is something that's annoyed me about Google the past few years.

FWIW, a full month in on iOS. I hate it. Most likely coming back in 23 months.

**mosincredible** • 3mo ago

Pixel 10 Pro PW4 45 LTE

This is how I feel. A Pro iPhone with my personal photographic style is my overall preferred camera but iOS is something I still can not live with on my main device.

**JimmyNamess** • 3mo ago

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However my wife and her extended family love taking pictures for social media of family events and pets and such and are, and always have been, Apple everything people. However they constantly comment about how much better photos taken with my Pixel 10 Pro XL look after family events.

Also, my P10PXL consistently takes better action shots (moving subjects like young children, dogs, etc) than my wife's & sister-in-law's 17 Pro. Theirs are almost always blurry.

So while I agree the iPhone has better 3rd party support at this point by a large margin, if you're looking for a phone to take pictures the Pixel still has a slight edge imo but you really won't have a bad experience with either.

**acid-burn2k3** • 3mo ago

Honestly I just feel like the pixel glorious photography days are over. They're not bad but definitely not great anymore.

The issue for me is that they delivered consistant result since OG pixel, then since the pixel 6 they started to brighten up the shadows a lot, up to the 10 pro XL where camera is my least favorite feature in the phone.

It's like, for the pixel to shines theses days, it needs to be perfect angle, perfect sun-lit scene. Put some cloudy or overcast light and everything become muddy, colorless, muted ans blurry / artefact ish.

That's what you get for focusing ONLY on the software side of things while concurrent continuously upgrade their lens year to year with a softer post-process. Feels like Google is relying too much on A.I to make the photos looks good and so it just look unnatural in the end for most of my shots.

**DiscoMilk** • 3mo ago

Pixel 8 Pro

No they're not, they were the best a few years ago but everyone has caught up and surpassed them.

**hooyahat** • 3mo ago

What I don't like about my pixel 9 pro is that in the viewfinder, the photo looks amazing, then it does its post processing thing and sometimes it messes up the photo.

**therankin** • 3mo ago

Pixel 7 Pro

Yea. My 7 Pro is similar. Especially when I'm zoomed in. The picture sharpens so much it looks ridiculous sometimes.

**[deleted]** • 3mo ago

[Skip to main content](#)[Create](#)**rainbowsunrain** OP • 3mo ago

This is not a serious comment, but I'll engage you once. We, as in, Pixel users, Pixel fans. Now add something useful to this discussion.

**Ghostttpro** • 3mo ago • Edited 3mo ago

Default Google is slightly better. Because iPhone photos are sometimes too dull. But using photographic styles it's even. The gap between iPhone video is much wider in iPhones favor. Than the tiny difference between stills.

**Darkpurpleskies** • 3mo ago

Pixel 8 S25+

The iPhone 17 Pro has taken the lead here and is more versatile. Here's a more extensive comparison from a photographer <https://youtu.be/laxkwXYTdnw?si=tkfnFXQ9xKp3e8UP>. Hard to call the Pixel flagship by comparison.

**rainbowsunrain** OP • 3mo ago

To be honest though, I watched this video a while ago, and noted to myself I mostly preferred Pixel's output out of the three. The reviewer is definitely biased too.

**Darkpurpleskies** • 3mo ago

Pixel 8 S25+

for photos sure... but there isn't a big lead like there used to be. For video well it's just sad.

**Salseca** • 3mo ago**redpepper_reddit** • 3mo ago

Does the same processing get applied to both the default 12mp or high res 50mp?

I'm not sure which one to use. Storage is not a concern. I just want best quality

**Expensive_Finger_973** • 3mo ago

In my experience with Pixels, iPhones, and Galaxy's Google has lost a ton of ground on having the best smartphone photos in the game over the last couple of years.

If you take a standard photo in the same lighting conditions with a Pixel 10 Pro XL, iPhone 17 Pro Max, and Galaxy S25 Ultra you will get very similar results. Similar enough where I don't think it is really a big

[Skip to main content](#)[Create](#)**itsjust_green** • 3mo ago

Pixel 8 Pro

If Google can just figure out how to bring their video boost feature to work on device in a smaller model they'd for sure bridge that gap too. I'm not worried about their still photography performance, I think they're one of the best

**Awkward_Pace_4440** • 3mo ago

In short:

Pixel used to be the go to phone for photography

Nowadays:

Iphone has caught up and leads in several areas.

Samsung has caught up and leads in several areas.

Vivo is better hands down.

Oppo is better.

Huawei is better.

....

And in video, Pixel just lags behind so badly its not even funny, a 5 year old iphone has better video.

But google doesn't seem to care lol.

**Bigd1979666** • 3mo ago

Pixel 6

I did not think phone cameras have as big a gap as they have nice did when , for example, pixels first arrived on the scene. Most are very good point and shoot devices while I still think pixel does it better more often . That being said, the new iphone photos look good but I still can't stand the issues I've had on past iphones regarding navigation, notifications and such to justify buying it despite it's pros.

**gandalf-duh-grey** • 3mo ago

Pixel 9 Pro

The 50 MP camera does a decent job at still photography but the shutter speed is too slow for it to be practical for everyday photography. It does the "photography" part just fine; the "computational" part is what's underwhelming.

**Hevilath** • 3mo ago

Computational photograh, maybe. But it is not there in hardware.. Competitors are using much better sensors these days so they don't have to cheat in software for the picture and videos look good.



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